

- Bear component selection and assembly at a Build-A-Bear Workshop
- Going to a movie and then hanging out with friends at a sleepover
- Bowling at the bowling lanes
- Baseball and cookout

There are loads of choices, or rather, there are lots of businesses who are ready to take your birthday money; even my local “Y” is offering parties now that “will guarantee a perfect day for your child’s birthday.”

It is the charm of the hosts and pleasantness of the guests that matter. One of the nicest parties my kids and I have ever attended was held in the apartment complex where the family of the honoree (five-year-old girl named Samantha) lived. Ten or so kids and many of their parents gathered in the family’s living room, played (or supervised play) inside, walked together to the on-site playground, trekked back to the apartment, enjoyed cake and ice cream, and talked.

The parents were kind enough to allow me to bring my younger child in addition to my older son (the invited guest); in fact, they welcomed everyone and remarked that my then-two-year-old, who enjoyed building and taking things apart and pushing

buttons (which some people find annoying), would likely become an inventor and live off royalties, just like Samantha’s uncle. What made the party great: party hosts who seemed to truly enjoy their guests’ company, unstructured play, and the chance for parents to mingle.

But backyard events are not always so simple. A few years ago, I planned what I thought was going to be a frugal, fun party: a few guests; cake and ice cream; and some cool games. I bought Harry Potter paper goods, decorations, and party favors from a birthday celebration catalog. I figured since I was holding the party at home at no cost, I could afford a themed event at a cost of about \$100.

Researching, evaluating, and organizing a series of activities took awhile. Supplies for the games added some to my expenses. A game that I thought would occupy the kids for a half-hour lasted about five minutes; another game that I was sure would be a huge hit (sticker tag) was rejected by one child, shortening its life at the party.

Since then, I’ve opted for single activity-based parties: a basketball party for a handful of kids held on our driveway; a baseball party for a slew of classmates held at a public park (rental fee of \$10); and a sleepover with enough children to entertain